

SECTION 2

Building Relationships and Trust

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Encouraging Your Team to Be Open with You

by Amanda Reill

When you become a manager, the power dynamics with your former peers will inevitably shift. You're now responsible for evaluating their performance. Their job security is contingent on you. Your relationships will, and should, change.

For example, you may notice a shift in the way your direct reports give you information. While the individuals on your team may have once felt comfortable casually sharing their frustrations with you, that may no longer be the case when you step into a management role. The founder of Pixar, Ed Catmull, addresses this reality in his book *Creativity, Inc.*—the story of Pixar's company culture from its early beginnings to the strength it holds today. He said, "It simply doesn't occur to [new managers] that after they get promoted to a leadership position, no one is going to come out and say, 'Now that you are a manager, I can no longer be candid with you.' Instead, many new leaders assume, wrongly, that their access to information is unchanged."

This is a major challenge for managers. But access to watercooler information—what employees are disgruntled about, what ideas they wish leadership would listen to, what systems aren't working—is critical to your success.

So, how do you maintain trust? How do you make sure your team still feels comfortable walking up to you and voicing their opinions?

Notice When Things Go Silent

When you're a manager, you may notice that the frustrations your team feels about their work, company leadership—or you—go silent. And those frustrations are valuable data to you as a leader. But to assume no news is good news is not a wise option. Instead, start with the assumption that your watercooler badge has been taken away.

The sentiment, "For sure, boss! All good over here!" comes from people who are interested in keeping their jobs and not making waves. Being honest about frustrations in the workplace can be a risky endeavor, after all. Though we optimistically hope that we've created a safe place for people to challenge the status quo, when 36% of people are worried about losing their jobs, the reality is a bit trickier than that.¹

Team health depends on honest feedback. If people keep their frustrations quiet, they may begin to lean toward quietly quitting or leaving the team altogether. This is one reason it's imperative for managers to create "psychological safety," a term coined by Harvard Business School professor Amy Edmondson that she sums up as "a belief that one will not be punished or humiliated for speaking up with ideas, questions, concerns, or mistakes, and that the team is safe for interpersonal risk-taking."²

How do you establish psychological safety with your team, which may now feel that being honest with you is a bit more risky?

Address the Elephant in the Room

If you're new to your role, try to address the new power differential within the first one or two weeks. Explain to your team what success looks like in your new role, how it depends on the team, and how much you want to continue to collaborate with them, support them, and help them grow.

You might say something like, "Hey folx, I wanted to gather everyone together to talk about this next season for our team. I have a different role now and I want to use it to make things better. I don't want to lose your trust in the process, and I want you to know that I'm committed to creating a psychologically safe work environment where we feel comfortable speaking candidly, disagreeing, and sharing ideas without fear of repercussions."

If you've been in your role for a while and are just now noticing a change in openness, schedule a meeting with your team to establish some ground rules for feedback. It's important to create a smooth runway for people to provide feedback by telling them where and when you plan to collect it. Can they send you their feedback via email, put it in a feedback box, walk up to you during the open-door hour, or share it over Slack?

Some may have their reasons for being uncomfortable sharing their views directly. Maybe they're more comfortable with giving it anonymously or sharing it via another person because of your power differential. Provide alternative routes for communication if they're having trouble communicating with you for any reason. This could be a designated person in HR, another manager, a team lead, or anyone else you trust to act as a responsible mediator.

Take Yellow Flags Seriously

People give you information about their temperature every day. When an employee begins exhibiting red-flag signals that they're not happy, it could be too late. Learn to look for yellow flags. Here are a few:

- Pay attention to facial expressions on Zoom and follow up with people individually when something seems off. You could say, "Hey, I noticed you didn't seem quite yourself this morning—just wanted to check in and see if you were doing OK or if you had additional thoughts about the meeting."
- Assume that anything anyone does tell you is the tip of an iceberg. If someone brings a complaint to you, such as a difficulty with a coworker, there is a chance they're holding back so they don't seem disgruntled. Validating their concerns is important to understanding if the situation is worse than they're letting on. You could ask, "How long have you been feeling that way?" or "What else have you noticed?" to see if the person has more to share.
- Any change in behavior is worth wondering about, such as a change in someone's schedule, a lack of eye contact, or uncharacteristic quietness. Something like quietness isn't a negative signal in and of itself, but the key is noticing whether something has changed. The behavior change may have nothing to do with work, but when you check in, the person may share with you a personal struggle that you'll be glad you're aware of.

The best way to handle yellow flags is with empathy and validation. Raising a concern feels risky, so your team members need to know that they can trust you before they'll be willing to share their concerns. Start by acknowledging the person's courage and initiative in trying to deal with a sticky situation or for opening up to you. Make sure you hear them out entirely before beginning to problem-solve, explain, or defend. For instance, if someone on your team has felt uncomfortable with the way a client was treating them, don't be quick to dismiss it before hearing them out. You can say, "I know it was probably not easy for you to bring this up, but I'm so thankful you did. I can understand why that would be uncomfortable."

When possible, don't neglect the power of an apology. After thoroughly listening, consider whether you can offer an apology to the person for ways the company could have supported them better. For instance, in the case described earlier, trying to create a zero-tolerance policy for toxic clients and showing your employees that they are more important than the bottom line would give you an opportunity to "put your money where your mouth is."

Optimize Your EQ

Emotional intelligence (EQ) is our ability to perceive, interpret, and manage our own emotions, as well as recognize and influence the emotions of those around us. It acknowledges that humans aren't machines, and they bring their emotions with them to work every day. An effective manager has a good understanding of *how* these emotions impact their team's work and leads their team in collective EQ upskilling.

As you work to build trust and openness on your team, meet regularly to hone your collective EQ. Explore the following questions together:

- What personalities, communication styles, and working styles are present on our team?
- What do you each need from me as a manager and from each other as teammates?
- What processes do we currently use for resolving conflict, providing feedback, and generating ideas? How comfortable are we with disagreements?
- How good is our team with managing failure?

Gather the team's answers to these questions, identify areas of improvement, and set some goals.

For instance, you may discover that your team feels like there's a lack of consistency in how new ideas are rolled out in the organization. Maybe they're not sure when and where to provide their opinions about changes that impact their individual workflows. Or perhaps there's a disconnect between your leaders and those who implement their visions, meaning you need to build a stronger communication bridge.

Once you're aware of these issues—whatever they may be—you can take steps to resolve them. This often starts by recognizing each person's strengths and challenge areas, respecting them, and establishing workflows that benefit everyone. Sometimes it may also involve giving feedback to stakeholders outside of your team, particularly if the problem is trickling down from leadership.

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The most important thing to remember when moving to managing people is that the dynamic *will* change. It has to. Addressing that fact up front and establishing new, trusting relationships with your colleagues will give you the best chance at a cohesive, transparent team moving forward.

QUICK RECAP

Access to information about what isn't working is critical to a manager's success. But how can you encourage your team to give you that information?

- Don't assume that no news is good news. You must establish psychological safety, so your team feels safe being honest with you.
 - Create a smooth runway for people to provide feedback by telling them where and when you plan to collect it.
 - Pay attention to signs that something may be off with your direct reports, such as facial expressions, uncharacteristic quietness, or schedule changes.
 - As you work to build trust and openness on your team, meet regularly to hone your collective emotional intelligence.
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Adapted from "Encouraging Your Team to Be Open with You (as a New Manager)," on hbr.org, July 4, 2023.

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Five Ways Leaders (Accidentally) Erode Trust

by Ron Carucci

As a manager, your top priority is establishing trust with your team. Your direct reports must have confidence in your ability to make decisions, communicate effectively, and help them grow in order to perform to the best of their abilities.

But establishing trust takes time, and the natural stressors of being a people leader can make it even harder. If you're not careful, your efforts to prove yourself as a capable leader may end up eroding, rather than strengthening, the foundation of trust you aim to build. And depending on how you arrived in your new role—promoted from within the team, brought in from another department, or hired from outside the company—you may face unique circumstances that make this process even more challenging.

Here are five common ways leaders unwittingly erode trust and how to avoid them.

Using Your Expertise to Coach or Help

One of the hardest things to do as a manager is to let go of the expertise and work that set you apart as an individual contributor. This is especially precarious when you are promoted from within your team or organization.

When leading people who do the work that you once did, it's easy to want to hold them to the standard you performed at. Your ability to do this work well is likely how you distinguished yourself and got your promotion. You may fear that if your direct reports aren't able to do the work as well as you did, it will reflect poorly on your leadership. In addition, the intangible aspects of leadership may make you unconsciously miss the tasks that you once found deeply gratifying—and that your team members are now responsible for.

As a result, you may be tempted to handhold, over-coach, or even do the work for them to demonstrate what you're looking for. But others rarely experience this as helpful. It can instead make them feel inadequate or see you as a micromanager. Once your team believes that you don't trust them with their work, they'll struggle to trust you with their growth and learning.

What to do instead

Help your direct reports master their tasks and projects in their own way. Assess their abilities against yours when you *started* doing the work—when you were first learning. Use your expertise judiciously, avoiding comparisons or being overly corrective. You can say something like, “Tell me how I can best use my experience in this work to help you grow.”

Be clear about your expectations around deliverables, key performance indicators, and deadlines. Agree on the outcomes you both believe they can achieve, and the approach they feel most comfortable taking (versus mimicking yours). Then, let them figure out how to achieve the goals you set, leveraging your guidance when they need it.

Trying to Build Rapport and a Sense of Egalitarianism

Many leaders struggle with the resulting power differential that occurs when they become a manager. This can be even more challenging if you're promoted from within your team and your former peers are now your direct reports. It can create a feeling of awkwardness and distance with individuals you previously felt close to.

To combat the discomfort, many leaders go out of their way to retain the same sense of rapport they once enjoyed as peers. This creates challenges later when you suddenly have to exercise your authority. Trying to pretend that things haven't changed that much won't help you build trust.

The hard truth is that once you become a leader, the relational boundaries with your former peers must shift. Similarly, if you were hired from the outside, you must set appropriate boundaries with your new team members. Your ability to socialize with them, what information you share with them, and what information they share with you must be carefully thought through.

What you can do instead

If you were promoted from within your company, having a proactive conversation with each person with whom your relationship has changed will enable you to clarify what they can expect from you as their leader. It also curtails the natural temptation they may have to curry favor with you or to leverage your past relationship for their personal gain. You might say something like, "I don't want the fact that we now share a reporting relationship to be awkward for us. But the reality is that some things must shift between us for us both to be successful. Let's talk about what parts of our relationship can stay intact and what parts we'll need to adapt."

If you were hired from the outside or are managing entirely new team members, start with a conversation that sets mutual expectations. You might begin with something like, "In new relationships, I find it helpful to share my expectations of others and to clarify their expectations of me as their leader. That way, we can do our best to help each other be successful."

Trying to Build Confidence by Looking Confident

Plenty of research shows that people are drawn to confidence in a leader. Many new leaders try to mask their insecurities by donning a leadership persona to appear confident. They speak in more declarative sentences, are overtly positive, and offer reassurances in the face of uncertainties.

But overconfidence can sometimes have the opposite effect, diluting trust by coming across as overly self-reliant, inauthentic, and out of touch. Yes, those you lead need to know you have confidence in yourself. But they also need to trust that you have confidence in *them* by acknowledging the areas where you aren't as strong and will need their help.

What you can do instead

Your confidence, in appropriate measure, is only one characteristic of leadership that will strengthen trust. If you rely on it excessively, you risk losing that trust when tough conditions make confidence impossible. You must balance confidence with humility, authenticity, and vulnerability so that the trust you earn is well-rounded and grounded in your full humanity. In the face of uncertainties—sudden strategic pivots, budget shortfalls, project setbacks—your team needs to know you are comfortable not having all the answers.

For example, one newly appointed leader I coached inherited a project that was way behind and had ballooned in scope. The team was frustrated, as was her boss. Feeling the pressure to get things on track quickly and reestablish the team's confidence, she was tempted to step in and start directing people on what to do. I urged her to instead consider that the team might find it more confidence-building if she acknowledged how tough things had been and engaged the team in coming up with solutions. This helped reestablish their self-confidence while also making them trust that she could listen and learn.

Checking In to Make Sure Everyone Is OK

If you tend to be a people-pleaser, you will be especially prone to this misstep. As you build relationships with your direct reports, checking in with them to see how they are adapting to your leadership and if you have to make any adjustments is a good idea. It's a great way to calibrate and demonstrate you are willing to modify if needed. It will build trust in your commitment to putting their needs first.

But in excess, these check-ins can begin to erode trust among your team members, particularly if you get defensive or don't act on their feedback. They may start to see your inquiries as manipulative and self-serving. When this happens, they may try to accommodate you by saying things are fine, further eroding their trust in your ability to make improvements.

What to do instead

Before seeking feedback from your team members, ask yourself if you're motivated by an actual desire to learn and adjust, or an unconscious need for validation and reassurance. While it's a good idea to invite feedback, you also want to empower your direct reports to initiate feedback conversations with you when they are feeling frustrated. This builds trust in your openness to their feedback by both soliciting it and inviting them to initiate it.

If you sense that someone you lead is feeling frustrated or unsatisfied, be specific in your inquiry and keep it focused on them. You might say something like, "I sense that something is frustrating you. Is there any way I can be helpful?" If they respond with a curt "No, I'm fine," then leave it with a simple "OK, I understand. But please know that, if something changes, I hope you'll let me know."

Too many new leaders, anxious to keep things harmonious, jump right to questions like, "Have I done something to upset you?" with the assumption that whatever's bothering the person is about them. This risks eroding trust by conveying that you are overly self-involved rather than genuinely concerned about them.

Building Credibility Through Past Successes

As a leader, you need to build credibility. You may be tempted to rely on your track record of positive results to make people trust your decision-making and leadership abilities. But overly relying on your past usually backfires. Leaders who have been hired from outside their current organization should be hyperaware of this mishap.

Resist starting sentences with, "Well, when I was at XYZ company, we approached this ..." People will accept one or two mentions of your past experiences because they know you don't have any other frame of reference. But after a while, they may start to hear it as an indictment of their approach and ideas. It can erode trust in your ability to adapt and work with others in this new context to find suitable solutions.

What to do instead

Whether you were promoted from within the organization or hired from outside, avoid leaning too much on your past successes. A better source of credibility and, therefore, trust is your curiosity. Ask your team questions about how they've tried to address current challenges or what ideas they've felt haven't been heard before. This gives you a body of knowledge that you can *build on* with your experience and enables you to contextualize past successes in the current situation. By demonstrating your willingness to adapt your ideas while learning from your team, you're more likely to build trust.

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Building and maintaining trust with your team is a long process. While you may be anxious about performing well in your role, it's important not to rush things. Listen to your feelings of anxiety and self-doubt, but don't let them weaken trust on your team. Stay focused on your larger goal of genuinely earning trust over time with your full humanity, experience, and desire to make your direct reports as successful as they can be.

QUICK RECAP

Here are five common ways managers unwittingly erode trust on their teams:

- **Using your expertise to coach or help.** Avoid micromanaging your direct reports; instead, help them master their projects in their own way.
 - **Trying to build rapport and a sense of egalitarianism.** Talk with each person on your team to clarify what they can expect from you.
 - **Trying to build confidence by looking confident.** Balance confidence with humility, authenticity, and vulnerability.
 - **Checking in to make sure everyone is OK.** Before seeking feedback, ask yourself if you actually want to learn and adjust, or simply need reassurance.
 - **Building credibility through past successes.** Lead with curiosity, rather than over-relying on your past achievements.
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Adapted from “5 Ways New Leaders (Accidentally) Erode Trust on Their Teams,” on hbr.org, March 18, 2024.

How do you repair trust on your team if you’ve lost it? Watch this video to find out:



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When You Can't Be Transparent with Your Team

by Ramona Shaw

There are many books and classes that describe leadership as a set of skills anyone can pick up over time. Things like listening and communication, time management, and conducting effective one-on-ones are just a handful of competencies that great leaders have. However, there is one significant skill that is often less talked about and even more difficult to learn: managing your emotions as someone in a position of power who has access to more information than others.

This is a dilemma many managers face: You know something that could impact your team, but you can't share it. How do you balance your values with your words and actions as a leader?

A client of mine recently faced this. She learned that she had to lay off 30% of her direct reports and that her boss would be replaced one week before she had to share the news with her team. When we spoke, she told me how emotional it was. She was upset about talented people being let go, worried about the morale and workload of the employees left behind, stressed about having a new boss, and in general, anxious about communicating a decision that was out of her control.

All of her emotions were valid. None of what she expressed was an indication of weakness or incompetence. Still, she wondered: Would senior leadership notice that she was having trouble staying focused? If she shared hints about what was coming, would it create uncertainty for her team and compromise her job? Should she question senior leadership, and if she did, would they think she didn't understand the big picture? Would her team lose trust and respect for her? Would people adapt with an open mindset?

This is a challenge that, as a manager, you will face time and again—whether it's a layoff, a reorganization, or a shift in your company's business initiatives. The good news is that there are ways to gracefully navigate it, and you should learn them. A growing body of research shows that when leaders leave their emotions unchecked, they make lower-quality decisions and negatively impact team performance, work culture, and employee motivation.¹

Here are a few tips to help you stay true to your leadership responsibilities despite the emotional challenge of hearing news you can't (yet) share with your team.

Remember That Your Job as a Leader Is to Represent the Company

Something many new managers overlook is that, as a leader of your organization, your job is to represent the organization. This comes with both spoken and unspoken responsibilities.

When you're privy to new information that you're not allowed to share with your team, you may feel pulled in two directions. As a manager, you're expected to represent the leadership team, but as an empathetic human being, you may also be tempted to prioritize your personal needs and relationships over the interests of the business.

Your job is to choose the former—to consider what the organization and your team need from you as a leader right now. If you choose to focus instead on what's best for your relationships, you risk leaking confidential information and eroding trust with the leadership team or potentially even losing your job.

Most often this dilemma occurs when there's a conflict between the information you learn and your personal values. If you're facing that conflict, try this exercise: Picture yourself in two different roles—the role of a leader and the role of a friend. Communicate with your team as a leader and extend compassion and patience as a friend.

For example, if you're being asked about rumors surrounding a layoff that you're unable to disclose, you could say, "There's nothing further I can communicate at this point, unfortunately. But I understand that these rumors are concerning. I feel the same way. Whatever happens, I will do my best to support you and the team. In the meantime, how can I be of help?"

Ground Yourself in Your Values and Principles

Good leaders are prepared leaders, and this includes having the ability to anticipate challenges. A clear set of values and principles will help you make good decisions, especially when you're feeling pulled in different directions. Don't wait for a difficult situation to land in your lap to figure out what principles guide you.

Take a moment now to consider what values you would want to honor should you find yourself in a situation where you have more information than you're allowed to share. Ask yourself:

- What do you stand for as a leader?
- How would you like others to describe your leadership style?
- What do you expect from your coworkers?
- Which of your personality traits are you most proud of?
- Which leaders do you admire most and why?

If transparency is a value of yours, a leadership principle connected to that might be to honor transparent communication both upward and downward (with your boss and with your employees). If you're unable to honor that, how will you address the friction you feel?

In this situation, I would advise people to consider all of their values. Perhaps, for instance, your other values are family, trustworthiness, and loyalty. How would making a compromise impact those aspects of your character? Would you lose your job and be unable to support your loved ones? Would you give up your reputation as a trustworthy team member and leader? Or could you make a compromise that would help you stay true to your values while also honoring your commitments to your employer?

For instance, you could tell a worried team member that you're unable to share information at this time but promise to do so as soon as you can and offer to talk through their anxious feelings. Often, there is a way to meet yourself—and others—in the middle.

If you're in a situation where you have information that violates your values, or may be unethical or discriminatory in any way, it's also your responsibility as a leader to do what you believe is right. You should discuss the situation with your manager or with your HR representative.

Share Your Principles with Others

Having a clear leadership philosophy that both you and your team understand—including a set of core values and principles—will not only help you make the best decision (for you), but it will also help you communicate it clearly to others.

For example, if 30% of my client's team members are laid off and a remaining employee were to ask my client if she knew about it beforehand, my client could concisely and clearly communicate the reason for her decision, letting her value of transparency guide her:

Yes, I received a heads-up from senior leadership. While transparency is really important to me, I had to take all aspects into consideration when deciding what information to share with you and other team members. To share the confidential information I was given sooner than I was permitted would have had

serious consequences for both the business and me. I really wish I could have been fully transparent with you and everyone else, and my goal is still to support you in any way I can. I hope you can understand what I based my decision on, knowing that there was no easy way to go about it. I understand it's not easy to hear this, and I'm here if you want to talk more about it or if you have more questions.

By stating your values and principles, your employees will likely feel a greater sense of trust and confidence in you because they'll recognize the thoughtful and proactive approach you took in making the decision.

Prioritize Respect Over Being Liked

You are in good company if you desire to be both liked and respected at work. The majority of us strive to feel appreciated and recognized on a team. These are basic human needs. But there will be times when you, as a leader, have to make tough decisions that not everyone will support. It's normal for some people to dislike you temporarily as a result.

If you lose sight of this and make decisions to be liked or to avoid hard calls, you will likely lose respect. Trying to lead a team that doesn't respect you or doesn't have confidence that you'll do what's right or what's best for their careers, even if it gets tough, will be a very difficult endeavor.

Bear this in mind when you feel tempted to say something or do something only to be liked or to prevent interpersonal tension. When you're able to manage your emotions, you're able to do the hard and right thing, instead of the easy and wrong thing. That will garner you respect.

Think Longer Term

In high-stress moments, it's easy to overlook the long-term perspective. Many of us tend to prioritize our short-term needs over our long-term gains. But trusted and respected leaders know that sharing confidential information to alleviate tension that they, alone, are experiencing, is ultimately more harmful than productive. It erodes trust and respect from senior leadership, peers, and employees alike. Particularly if you don't have all the details, sharing information with your team too soon can cause a whirlpool of stress and confusion. Typically, it's not worth it.

Let's take my client's situation as an example. If she had told someone on her team that layoffs were coming, but that she wasn't supposed to say anything, the recipient of that news may have initially felt appreciative and trusted her, but after that first rush of relief, secondary thoughts would have likely come up. The recipient may have wondered if they could ever trust their manager with confidential information of their own. They may also have worried about what else was said or done behind their back, or spread the confidential information to other people, following their manager's example.

Losing integrity at the expense of sharing confidential information is a common consequence. In the heat of the moment, it's easy to lose sight of that.

Don't Make Promises That You Can't Keep

Last, keep in mind that withholding confidential information for the organization's benefit doesn't mean that you need to invent an alternative story or make promises and commitments that you won't be able to fulfill.

As an example, in the early days of the Covid-19 pandemic, several of my clients shared that their senior leadership teams promised them that no layoffs would happen. But as the weeks went by, and the severity of the situation became clearer, my clients were faced with both furloughs and layoffs. These changes made sense for the businesses, but employee-manager trust was eroded in the process.

A better approach in these tricky situations is to be as honest and transparent as you can without leaking information. You could say, "While this may change, as of today, we've communicated that no layoffs are taking place," or, "I can't promise you a future decision, but what I can promise you is that I've got your back and will support you through any change that may come our way."

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Applying these six tips won't make your situation feel less emotional. In fact, demonstrating emotional maturity and being comfortable with the uncomfortable may be harder in the short term. But once the intensity dies down, the news is out, and this phase is over, you will have stayed true to your values and earned trust and respect that will benefit you for years to come.

QUICK RECAP

If you know something that could impact your team but you can't share it, how do you balance your values with your actions as a leader?

- Remember that your job as a leader is to represent the company.
 - Determine how you will address the friction you feel by leaning into your values.
 - Share your values with your employees to increase their trust and confidence in you.
 - Accept that there will be times when you must make decisions that everyone may not support.
 - Think longer term—sharing information too soon can cause a whirlpool of stress and confusion.
 - Don't make promises or commitments that you can't keep.
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Adapted from content posted on hbr.org, March 14, 2023.

For more on trust and transparency, listen to this podcast:

